How True Crime Shapes Moral Judgments of Victims

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INTRO

- Crime rates are declining, yet fear of victimization and true crime popularity are at all-time highs
- Drawing on defensive attribution theory[1], we propose true crime enthusiasts manage fear and feel in control by blaming victims

METHOD

- *N* = 284 online survey participants
- True crime consumption[2]: frequency engaging with true crime books, podcasts, TV, and movies (0 = never to 4 = very frequently; *M* = 6.90, *SD* = 4.27, range 0–16)
- Horror consumption: same format — included as fear-based media control (*M* = 5.71, *SD* = 4.37, range 0–16)
- Fear of crime[3]: 10-items (e.g., "I'm afraid of a crime happening to me"; 1 = very untrue to 6 = very true; *M* = 3.18, *SD* = 1.20)
- Threat control orientation[4]: coping style when facing danger (e.g., "When I sense my safety is in danger, I find a course of action to feel safe again"; 1 = not at all like me to 7 = very much like me; *M* = 5.02, *SD* = 1.21)
- Read two crime vignettes (between-subjects: blameless vs. culpable victim[5]) and rated victim and perp blame

Figure 1. True crime enthusiasts blame victims more, regardless of victim behavior



References
[1]Walster, E. (1966). *JPSP*. [2]McDonald, M., et al. (2021). *Arch. Sex. Behav.* [3]Etopio, A. & Berthelot, E. (2022). *Criminology Crim. Just. Law & Soc.* [4]Thompson, S. & Schlehofer, M. (2008). *PSPB*. [5]Dyer, R., et al. (2022). *Soc. Cog.*

Fearful people blame victims when they have no other way to feel safe

Figure 2. Fear of crime predicts victim blaming among people with low threat control



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RESULTS

True Crime Consumption and Victim Blaming Co-Occur *(Fig. 1)*

- As we preregistered, we identified high (≥+1 SD, *n* = 48) and low (≤-1 SD, *n* = 56) true crime fans — no linear relationship emerged in continuous analyses (*b* = 0.014, *p* = .325), and consumption did not predict blaming after controlling for fear, threat sensitivity, and gender (*b* = 0.020, *p* = .175)
- Heavy consumers were more likely to be male (58% vs. 39% of low consumers, *p* = .010); no differences in age, politics, or prior victimization
- Heavy consumers blamed victims more than light consumers (Figure 1; *p* = .036) — effect specific to true crime, null for horror (*p* = .414)
- High consumers are more fearful (*p* < .001) and threat-sensitive (*p* < .001) — blaming and heavy consumption appear to be co-occurring expressions of a threat-preoccupied disposition

Fear Predicts Victim-Blaming When Observers Lack Threat Control *(Fig. 2)*

- Returning to the full sample (*N* = 284) to test who shows a link between fear → blame
- Fear of crime alone does not predict victim blaming (*b* = 0.03, SE = 0.04, *p* = .453)
- Fearful people *who lack threat control* blame victims more (Fig 2. interaction term: *b* = 0.14, SE = 0.06, *p* = .032)
- No effect of fear among those with high threat control (*b* = −0.05, SE = 0.06, *p* = .38)
- This isn't because those without threat control are more punitive: Same interaction absent for perpetrator blaming (*b* = 0.01, SE = 0.02, *p* = .455)

DISCUSSION

- Momentary anxiety did not replicate the threat control moderation, suggesting victim blaming as a coping strategy is driven by chronic fear rather than in-the-moment emotions
- Just world beliefs independently predicted victim blaming (*p* = .028) but did not interact with fear, suggesting JWB promotes blaming as a stable worldview while threat control specifically buffers fear-driven blame
- Whether true crime shapes blaming or attracts blame-prone individuals, heavy consumers are an intervention target for where fearful, threat-preoccupied audiences already congregate. True crime media incorporating concrete threat control messaging could disrupt fear leading to victim-blaming.